operational plans in Afghanistan. Wary of getting bogged down in a long-term counter-insurgency or nation-building, the US was aiming for a crisp military campaign to root out terrorism. From an Indian standpoint, this was impossible.

Gautam Mukhopadhaya, India's ambassador to Afghanistan (2010–13) and the liaison officer part of the team that opened India's embassy in Kabul 2001, concurs that India was given very limited space to operate in Afghanistan. 'Though we [India] came on the back of victory of the Northern Alliance and ouster of the Taliban, the US was a very powerful factor in Afghanistan', he says.[128] The US influenced the UN thinking, as there was a lot of sensitivity towards Pakistan's demands. The western diplomatic community was wary of Indian presence. Despite the fact that the UF, which was a substantial component of the Karzai government, backed strong relations with India, Karzai too was prone to thinking that Afghanistan was a victim of India-Pakistan rivalry.[129] Apparently, US views on India's security role in Afghanistan evolved between November 2001 (when Blair visited New Delhi) and April 2002, making it difficult for India to expand its security profile in Afghanistan. The gap between India and the US on the war on terror grew so much in these months that when the Kaluchak massacre in J&K happened on 14 May 2002, a livid Congress party leader Pranab Mukherjee tore into Jaswant Singh for making false promises based on exaggerated expectations about India being a beneficiary of the US war in Afghanistan.[130] Criticising Washington's double standards and the BJP's support for the same, Mukherjee asked 'how does one justify that you are fighting terrorism by co-opting a country which has accepted terrorism as a State policy?'[131]

Officials from India's National Security Council Secretariat (NSCS) underline the bureaucracy's conservatism towards the US in Afghanistan well after 2001. Benoy Khare, former Assistant Director of the Joint Intelligence Committee (JIC) at the NSCS, who analysed intelligence reports from all Indian spy agencies, says, 'all of them, the MEA, the R&AW, the IB, the MI, they came and told us, "don't trust the Americans", they will not help you do what you want to do in Afghanistan.'[132] But these were years when people like K Subrahmanyam, with support from Brajesh Mishra and later NSA M. K. Narayanan, were trying to change the bureaucracy's outlook towards the US. Indeed, Manmohan Singh